

Public

Ref: FOI/26/032

National Energy System Operator

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28 May 2026

Dear requester

Request for Information

Thank you for your request for information which was received by NESO on 28 April 2026.

Your request has been considered under the Environmental Information Regulations 2004 (EIR) as the requested information falls within the definition of environmental information in Regulation 2(1)(c) of the EIR.

Request

Following our response to your request about the Rufus data centre (FOI/25/329), you explained that you were finding it difficult to understand the complexities of the Gate 2 requirements for either generation or demand connections:

1. You asked if we could direct you to where on our website you could find the difference between the criteria needed to get Gate 2 connection agreements for demand only connections rather than generation connection agreements.
2. You also explained that it would be helpful to understand when the Rufus data centre is likely to be operational and what the criteria are for grid connection.

Our response

We confirm that we hold information in scope of your request.

1) The published [Connections Reform methodologies](#) explain how we determined whether projects meet the Gate 2 criteria. In summary, all projects (or the relevant stages of a project) must meet both the Gate 2 Readiness Criteria and the Gate 2 Strategic Alignment Criteria to receive a Gate 2 Offer.

Technologies in scope of the [UK Government's Clean Power 2030 Action Plan](#) (CP30 Action Plan) must be assessed against the 2030 and 2035 capacity ranges before they can be deemed to have met the Gate 2 Strategic Alignment Criteria. Transmission Connected Demand projects and other technologies out of scope of the CP30 Action Plan will automatically meet the Strategic Alignment Criteria (d) (see Section 6.3 of the [Gate 2 Criteria Methodology](#)).

Paragraph 7.7 of the [Connections Network Design Methodology](#) sets out the process for transmission connected demand projects that have met the Gate 2 Readiness Criteria, i.e. they have secured land rights or validation of application for planning consent:

7.7 Projects not in scope of the CP30 Action Plan in the Gate 2 Tranche

7.7.1 Transmission connected demand and other out of scope technologies listed in Section 7.2 that have met the Gate 2 Readiness Criteria will be assessed and provided with a Gate 2 offer. These projects will be sorted into Phase 1, Phase 2, or after Phase 2 (2035+) within a Gate 2 Tranche depending on their requested connection date and their Gate 2 Readiness Date (or the date planning consent was obtained, or the date a relevant (i.e. Protection Clause 2b) support contract was signed (or the equivalent), if applicable). The MW volume of these projects in each phase will however not be bound by a permitted capacity as is the case for projects in scope of the CP30 Action Plan.

For projects not in scope of CP30, these were placed in phase 1 (2026–2030) if they:

- i. Met the readiness criteria; and
- ii. already had a firm connection date before end 2030; or
- iii. had a connection date of 2031 or later, but requested advancement to a connection date
- iv. before end 2030 and passed the Transmission Owner 'advancement check'.

For projects not in scope of CP30, these were placed in phase 2 (2031–2035) if they:

- i. Met the readiness criteria; and
- ii. already had a firm connection date between 01/01/2031 and 31/12/2035; or
- iii. had a connection date of 01/01/2036 or later, but requested advancement to a connection
- iv. date before end 2035.

2) In our response to your previous request (FOI/25/329) we confirmed that we held some recorded information relating to the connection agreement and contractual information for the Rufus project. We explained that NESO cannot disclose information relating to specific developers or their projects, other than where that information is already publicly available. We are unable to

provide any further information we hold in relation to the project for the reasons explained in our previous response.

This concludes our response to your request.

Next steps

If you are dissatisfied with our handling of your request, you can ask us to review our response. If you want us to carry out a review, please let us know within 40 working days and quote the reference number at the top of this letter. You can find our procedure here: [Freedom of Information and Environmental Information Regulations | National Energy System Operator](#). The ICO's website also provides guidance on the internal review process: [What to do if you are dissatisfied with the response | ICO](#).

If you are still dissatisfied after our internal review, you can complain to the Information Commissioner's Office (ICO). You should make complaints to the ICO within six weeks of receiving the outcome of an internal review. The easiest way to lodge a complaint is through their website: www.ico.org.uk/foicomplaints. Alternatively, they can be contacted at: Wycliffe House, Water Lane, Wilmslow, SK9 5AF.

Thank you for your interest in the work of the National Energy System Operator (NESO).

Regards,

The Information Rights Team, National Energy System Operator (NESO)